



Department of Civil and Environmental Engineering (CIVL)

Environmental Biotechnology for Resource Recovery and Sustainability Group



Application Guidebook

The Hong Kong University of Science and Technology (HKUST)

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Overview

About The Program

Welcome to the Department of Civil and Environmental Engineering. Our research group, *Environmental Biotechnology for Resource Recovery and Sustainability group*, is led by Prof. Samir Kumar Khanal. We focus on advancing innovative solutions in anaerobic digestion and micro-aeration, nanobubble technology, bioenergy and biofuels, gas fermentation, machine learning, resource recovery and aquaponics. The group trains graduate students (MPhil and PhD) to work diligently, design experiments that address pressing environmental challenges, and think creatively to develop novel approaches that contribute meaningfully to science and sustainability.

Mission

Our mission is to advance sustainable resource recovery and environmental biotechnology through pioneering research in environmental field. We apply state-of-the-art technology to address environmental challenges, while training students to become leaders in biotechnology, bioenergy and environmental engineering. Through collaborative research across HKUST, regional institutions, and international partners (50+ alumni & 15 active researchers), we foster innovation and deliver sustainable solutions with global impact.

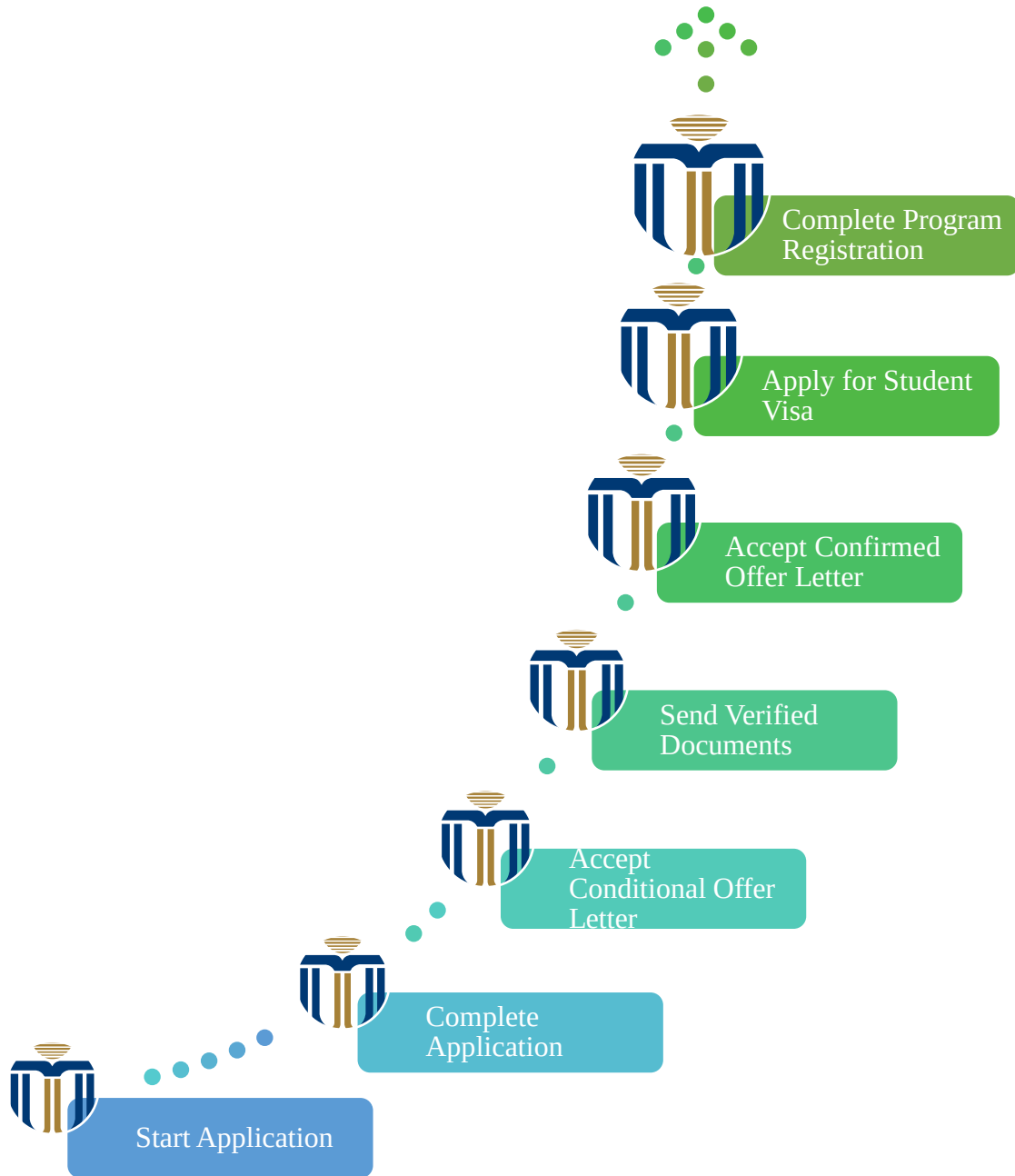
Learning Outcomes

Graduate students in the *Environmental Biotechnology for Resource Recovery and Sustainability group* at HKUST will be able to develop strong foundation in environmental engineering, combining scientific rigor with practical problem-solving approaches. They will be able to develop core concepts and showcase them in real-world applications, sharpen their academic and experimental skills, and cultivate innovative thinking. Communication is an important part of graduate's journey so we aim to provide friendly environment for effective collaboration and harness their ability to communicate with confidence at national and international conferences. Ultimately, graduates will be able to navigate through complex environmental challenges and emerge as leaders in their field to drive sustainable goals and contribute to society.

Objective

The purpose of this handbook is to guide graduate applicants swiftly through the admission process for their smooth enrollment in HKUST. This document aims to clear any confusions that may arise during applicant's admission procedure and help them to complete their application within the designated timeline. We welcome graduate students both in **spring** and **fall** term and try to provide clear instructions to support them during the entire process of enrollment. We hope this guide will serve as a roadmap for admission, ensuring clarity at every step, aid applicants to navigate through the process effectively and help them to begin their journey with confidence.

Timeline For Admission Procedure



1.General Information

Field	Details
Award Title	Master of Philosophy in Civil Engineering: MPhil (CIVL) Doctor of Philosophy in Civil Engineering: PhD (CIVL)
Normative Program Duration	MPhil: 2 years PhD: 3 years (with relevant research Master's), 4 years (without relevant research Master's)
Offering Unit	Department of Civil and Environmental Engineering
Program Advisor	PG Programs Coordinator: Prof. Samir Khanal , Professor of Civil and Environmental Engineering
Website	https://ce.hkust.edu.hk/Programs-and-Admissions/Postgraduate-Programs
Enquiry	civilweb@ust.hk

2. Admission Requirements

For **MPhil** students, applicants are required to hold a **bachelor's degree** from a recognized institution, preferably with **GPA >3.0**, or have an approved equivalent qualification. Applicants are expected to have the foundational knowledge and have relevant background to environmental engineering or related discipline.

Officially, for **PhD** students, they are required to hold a **bachelor's degree** with outstanding performance record, but we would appreciate applicants already having a **master's degree** in the relevant field, ensuring they have the necessary foundation to engage in advanced research and coursework required for PhD program.

We value graduate students who demonstrate good proficiency in English. The minimum requirement to fulfill English language requirements are as follow:

Requirement	Details
TOEFL iBT	4.5 *
TOEFL pBT	550
TOEFL Revised Paper-Delivered Test	60 (total scores for Reading, Listening, and Writing sections)
IELTS (Academic Module)	Overall score: 6.5 All sub-scores: 5.5*
Notes	* Refers to scores in one single attempt only. Test-at-home option is not accepted.
Exemptions	Applicants are not required to present TOEFL or IELTS scores if: • Their first language is English, or • They obtained a bachelor's degree (or equivalent) from an institution where the medium of instruction was English.
Note: If an applicant has obtained their degree from a university where the medium of instruction (MOI) is English, they may request an official MOI certificate from their institution. In such cases, applicants are not required to take an English language proficiency test (TOEFL or IELTS), provided the certificate is issued by the central university authority and confirms English as the sole medium of instruction.	

3. Admission Timeline

Application Fee: HK\$180

Stage	Fall Intake (Starts September)	Spring Intake (Starts February)
Applications Open	September 1 (of the prior year)	September 1 (of the prior year)
HKPFS Deadline (PhD only)	December 1	Not applicable
Main Application Deadlines	June 1 (Non-local Applicants) July 15 (Local Applicants)	November 1 (Non-local Applicants) December 15 (Local Applicants)
Admission Offers Issued	September to August	September to January
Program Registration	Mid-August	Mid-January
Term Commences	September 1	February 1

Applicants are encouraged to follow the above-mentioned timeline rigorously and begin their application process as early as possible, so they can receive their offer letter promptly and have sufficient time to apply for and obtain a visa.

4. Documents Required

Applicants are encouraged to prepare documents before applying for the program for smooth application procedure. For the initial stage (before obtaining **conditional offer letter**), applicants can **scan and upload** the documents themselves without requiring any verified documents from their home university.

- Note:**
1. **Verified documents are the attested documents (copy of the original document that are stamped and signed) required to be sent by the applicant's central university directly to HKUST with the official mail mentioned on their website.**
 2. **HKUST never asks for the original documents to be sent directly during the entire application procedure.**

Following are the list of documents required for applying in CIVL program:

1. **Identity document:** Passport/social security card (International), Hong Kong ID (local) Mainland ID card/EEP/passport (Mainland)
2. **Official transcripts & degree certificate** (bachelor/master), latest transcript if the program is not yet completed.
In case where applicant has completed the program and waiting for the final degree certificate to be issued or if they are in the final year of their program, they can upload provisional certificate (if issued) and later (after receiving offer letter), letter of graduation stating your **name, ID no., program of study, letterhead** of your home institution, **name** and **position** of the person authorized to issue certificate, **grades** and **grading scale** (e.g. 80% out of 100%, 3.5 GPA out of 4 GPA) and **official stamp** of your home institution
3. **Grading system/grading scales** (100%, 4 GPA), usually found at the back of transcript
4. **Proof of English proficiency** (IELTS, TOEFL, MOI)
5. **Proposed research plan:** Maximum of 3-to-4-page draft of research plan with proper in-text citations and references. Applicants are encouraged to discuss about the proposed research plan with their supervisor beforehand and prepare a clear and concise draft

5.Start Your Application

Click [here](#) to go to the application page.

1. Create account on online admission system (OAS).
2. Fill up basic information such as **contact info**, **educational background**, **English language result**, **publications** (if any), **references** (2-3), and **supporting documents** (if any).
Note: Public examination score is not mandatory for our program.
3. References can be sent before or after the application fee has been paid. We'd suggest applicants to have their references sent before paying the fee.
4. For both MPhil and PhD applicants, even though the OAS asks for your highest degree of education, **bachelor information is a must**. Without providing bachelor's education information, **applicants will not be able to receive their offer letter**.
5. Double check the application to ensure the information provided is accurate.
6. Pay the application fee and submit the application.

After submitting the application, applicants should check OAS at least once a day and be up to date with their application status. Once verified by HKUST, applicants will receive a **conditional offer letter**.

Applicants should notify their supervisor/department immediately if there is a substantial delay in getting the offer letter even though applicants submitted the application early or if the deadline for issuing the offer letter is near (*refer to admission timeline*).

Note: The deadline for issuing the offer letter to international applicants is earlier than local/mainland applicants. For exact deadline, applicants may ask to the department/supervisor.

After obtaining conditional offer letter;

1. Applicants are required to send **verified documents** such as **official transcript**, **degree certificate**/provision/letter of graduation (*refer to 2nd point of documents required*), **grading system/scale**, and **MOI certificate** via their central university (*refer to note 1 of documents required*) to pgdoc@ust.hk.
2. English test scores should be sent by the official institution (IDP, British Council) to HKUST via their official email.

Note: Check 'Document Checklist' on OAS at least once a day. HKUST team will give some comments on the 'Remark' section. Click on 'View' to see the comments. Sometimes they require additional/supporting documents to verify the application. Make sure to provide the required documents within designated timeline.

After completing above-mentioned steps, applicants will receive **confirmed offer letter** and will be invited for **program registration** (*refer to program registration section*). Applicants are required to pay **HK\$5,000** to accept the offer.

6.Start Your Student Visa Application

Applicants will be invited to apply for the e-visa after receiving & accepting conditional offer letter. Visa application platform can be accessed after logging into OAS.

Application period for student visa application:

1. Fall admission: March or soonest possible
2. Spring admission: mid-October or soonest possible

Applicants are required to:

1. Download and complete the visa application form (available on OAS) and color print it.
2. Print colored copy of travel document (e.g., Passport).
3. Bank certificate (original) with applicant's **name**, **account no.**, **official bank letterhead**, and **current exchange rate** (e.g., 1US\$=...HK\$)
4. Print colored copy of conditional offer letter.

Applicants can view this [sample](#) to complete their visa application.

- Pay the visa application fee **HK\$1,000**.
- Arrange all of the above documents in a parcel and use [mailing cover](#) outside of it and have it delivered via courier service. Fill up your **name**, **application no.** and **program of study** on the mailing cover. All the information required by the courier service is in the mailing cover.
- Check your student visa application status at least once a day.
- Upon receipt of a properly filed application, the University will act as your sponsor, monitor the progress, and update the online visa application status.
- Once approval is granted by the Immigration Department (IMMD), the University will advise you to download the e-Visa, which will serve as your entry permit to Hong Kong for study.
- If additional information is required, please click [here](#).

Note: Fall semester is the busiest semester. Applicants may need to wait a bit more to get the offer letter and visa as compared to the spring semester.

7. Program Registration

After accepting the confirmed offer letter, applicants will be invited to complete their program registration shortly (usually 2-3 days after receiving the letter).

HKUST will send an invitation email for the registration.

1) Activate your HKUST Account	https://myaccount.ust.hk/passwd/studentAcctActivation (Enquiry: cchelp@ust.hk)
2) Complete the Online Registration Form	https://registry.hkust.edu.hk/online-reg (Login with your University email address: [account name] @connect.ust.hk)
3) Upload the personal identification and visa documents (if applicable)	
4) Upload your photo for Student Card	

The online registration form requires **landing slip** which the applicant will receive in immigration section up on arrival in Hong Kong.

Upload the landing slip and collect your **student ID** after 2-3 days of completing the registration.

For further assistance, contact our members:

Dr. Surendra KC- surendra@ust.hk

Gokarna Chand- gchand@connect.ust.hk

We welcome you to the HKUST CIVL community